



LIVING WITH THE  
GHOST OF SAM

BOOK EIGHT

THE STRANGE  
EMERGENCE OF MS. PEEL

DEREK DEVON

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To my step-kids,

who taught me that family isn't something you're born into — it's something that shows up, moves in, rearranges the furniture, and makes the house feel alive.

And let's not forget their most important contribution: my incredible grandkids, who prove the punchlines skip a generation and land even harder.

Ravencrest could take lessons.

## THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

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Book Four — Last Laugh

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## CHAPTER ONE

### THE 3:33 AM BALLET

*Here's something they don't teach you in comedy school, kid: the quiet ones always have the best material. Thirty years I spent screaming my lungs out to get a laugh, and meanwhile the guy fixing the furnace has a whole show running at home that nobody's ever seen. And the ladies? Forget it. You spend your whole life thinking you married a gallery girl, and one morning she comes downstairs wearing a green cardigan and a secret, and suddenly you're living with a spy. OH OH OHHHH — roll it.*

The cottage sat at the edge of the Ravencrest grounds like a footnote nobody read, which was exactly how its occupant preferred it.

Inside, it was part workshop, part living space, and entirely Larry. Circuit boards and computer parts had organized themselves into artistic patterns on the walls — not been organized, organized *themselves*, in the sense that Larry had arranged them and would deny to his grave that the arrangement was art. Blueprints covered every flat surface, many bearing the mansion's distinctive geometric designs, annotated in Larry's careful hand.

An ancient digital clock flipped to 3:33 AM.

The Christmas lights strung across the ceiling illuminated in sequence, and the machine began.

A marble rolled down a track. The marble triggered a series of Hot Wheels cars, which shot around a loop with the urgency of tiny

commuters. The last car struck an old computer fan, which whirled to life and blew a paper airplane across the room, where it struck — nose first, dead center, a landing that would have made its designer weep — the PLAY button on an ancient iPod dock.

"The Power of Love" filled the cottage through speakers built from repurposed 1950s drive-in movie theater equipment.

In the bed, a figure stirred: Larry Leland, wearing his originally issued Star Wars pajamas, complete with attached booties, topped with an Iron Man nightcap. He reached for the heavily modified Sony Walkman on the nightstand — its exposed circuits glowing with the same blue energy as the mansion's systems — and clipped it to his chest like a medical device.

"Good morning, Mr. Leland," said an automated voice through a vintage speaker. "Quantum readings optimal. Recommended playlist activated."

The headphones settled over his ears.

And Larry Leland — quiet, deferential, speak-when-spoken-to Larry Leland — melted away. In his place rose a man mid-air-guitar-solo, his movements a charming collision of Doc Brown's manic energy and something entirely, gloriously his own.

In the bathroom, the showerhead — connected to an elaborate water recycling system — displayed its temperature through embedded LEDs while "Mr. Roboto" played through waterproof speakers.

"Water temperature: optimal," the shower reported in robotic monotone. "Usage: 2.3 gallons. Dance mode engaged."

Through the fogged glass, Larry's silhouette performed surprisingly coordinated robot moves while shampooing, the LEDs pulsing in sync, man and plumbing in perfect mechanical communion.

By the time "She Blinded Me with Science" kicked in, he was at the kitchen counter — a normal kitchen counter, right up until a hidden button split it open to reveal a combination rowing machine and bicycle generator.

"Power generation initiated," the display announced. "Breakfast sequence activated. Tempo matching music."

Each rowing stroke powered a different appliance while Larry bobbed his head in perfect time. The coffee maker released a puff of steam on every "Science!" The toaster popped in rhythm. The monitors displaying mansion diagnostics pulsed with the beat, like backup dancers who also happened to be doing their jobs.

The morning proceeded as liturgy. He tested equipment in the workshop with a wrench for a microphone while Donna Summer insisted that she worked hard for the money, and the gadgets around him seemed to pulse along in solidarity. The music slid into Oingo Boingo's "Weird Science" as he packed his temperature-controlled lunch, drumming briefly on the counter with two carrots, hitting the air-sax break at precisely the right moment while arranging containers in the specialized compartments of a custom lunchbox whose quantum cooling system hummed harmony.

ZZ Top's "Sharp Dressed Man" brought the wardrobe portion of the program. Larry executed the exact dance move from the video — the little synchronized pivot, nailed — while donning his farmer-looking overalls, and the morning light through the workshop windows caught the modifications: hidden pockets, specialized tool loops, softly glowing quantum sensors, all of it shimmering with each rotation.

The performance concluded at the computer corner, where "The Final Countdown" accompanied his typing — rendered, naturally, as though he were playing the synthesizer intro himself, fingers arched, head tilted back — as he checked screen after screen of

mansion diagnostics, their soft blue glow matching the dawn now filling the cottage.

Through every transition, the Christmas lights overhead shifted colors to match each song's tempo and mood. Larry's home, it turned out, was as responsive to music as the mansion itself. They were, in every way that mattered, related.



Dawn proper found him wheeling out his modified vintage bicycle, its frame housing glowing computer components that matched the mansion's circuits. He could not resist one final air guitar riff before mounting — Judas Priest's "Riding on the Wind" demanded no less.

"Quantum field detection: active," the bike's digital display reported. "Route to Ravencrest: optimal. Music sync engaged."

He pedaled through the coastal mist, his helmet's readout tracking rising quantum energy, one hand occasionally lifting from the handlebars to conduct an imaginary orchestra while the bike's electric hum supplied the bass line.

Ahead, out of the fog, materialized old Mr. Rogan, walking his ancient dog Muddles at the pace Muddles had negotiated years ago and never renegotiated.

"Top of the morning to you, Mr. Leland," Mr. Rogan called. "Looks like a lovely day is coming."

Larry nodded and smiled politely, having read the greeting entirely off Mr. Rogan's lips, the music in his headphones being at a volume best described as legally actionable. The fog swallowed Mr. Rogan and Muddles behind him, and Larry resumed head-bobbing his way toward the mansion.

At the service entrance, the transformation reversed. Headphones off. Walkman tucked away. Shoulders adjusted into their public setting: professional, unremarkable, invisible.



The mansion's children were not fooled for a second.

"Morning, dancing machine!" George Carlin's reflection greeted him from a brass wall sconce as "People Are Strange" began playing softly through the mansion's systems.

"Hey Larry! Man, you got more moves than a chess tournament!" Richard Pryor offered from a decorative mirror.

"I tell ya, this guy's got better moves than my first wife's divorce lawyer!" Rodney Dangerfield added from a glass cabinet.

Larry acknowledged each with a slight nod, composure fully installed. But down the hallway, when he was certain no one was watching, his walk acquired the faintest suggestion of choreography.

In the kitchen, Smithers was arranging breakfast with the precision of a man defusing a very delicious bomb.

"Good morning, Mr. Smithers. Fine day today."

Smithers responded with a knowing smile and slight bow, and pretended — with the professional discretion of his trade — not to notice Larry's foot tapping to the mansion's music.

In the hallway, Larry retrieved his tool belt from a Victorian coat rack that seemed to adjust its height for him, the mansion's geometric patterns pulsing softly at his presence like a cat purring. The pipe organ struck up "In the Hall of the Mountain King" as he reached the basement stairs. He paused at the top, checked the readings on a custom device, and the basement door swung open for him, unasked.

Down he went into the blue-tinged light, tool belt jingling in perfect rhythm with the music — and just before the darkness took him, he permitted himself one last small dance step.

The mansion, being family, told no one.



## CHAPTER TWO

# QUANTUM TOAST

Morning fog rolled back from Ravencrest like a receding tide. Contractor vehicles lined the circular drive, and workers moved about their tasks — replacing shutters, repairing roof tiles, repainting trim — while the mansion glowed softly in the early light, submitting to its makeover with the patience of a dowager at the salon.

Up the gravel drive came Nancy, jogging in high-end running gear, threading between ladders and building materials, her smart watch reading 7.2 miles. As she passed, every contractor on the property discovered a simultaneous need to pause his work, and one of them produced a whistle of a variety that human resources departments were invented to address.

She ignored it entirely. And somewhere beneath the ignoring — in a small, private, unexamined drawer — she filed away a flicker of pride anyway, sexist packaging and all. Seven-point-two miles at her age. Let them whistle.

The staff entrance opened silently for her. The kitchen was warm with morning light and the smell of baking, and Smithers stood at the massive island, crimping pie crust edges with surgical precision.

"Something smells amazing, Smithers." She pulled a water from the fridge.

"Apple pie, Miss Nancy. Though the apples insisted on arranging themselves in a rather precise geometric pattern this morning."

He lifted the top crust. Beneath it, the apple slices had arranged themselves in the mansion's wall patterns, rendered in fruit.

"The mansion's developing a culinary style?" Nancy toweled off her neck. "What's next — quantum toast?"

"I believe that's scheduled for next week," Smithers said, deadpan. "Though the toaster has been practicing."

Nancy watched him work for a while, toweling off, and something in the warm quiet of the kitchen loosened a drawer she hadn't meant to open.

"It's funny, Smithers, and I hope I am not bothering you, but I have recently — okay, the last couple of weeks — been revisiting old memories for some reason. Last night I was remembering back in high school, when Derek and I first started dating. He used to take me out in his father's old blue Pontiac station wagon he called 'Betsy.' I think a more accurate name would have been 'The Make-out Machine.'" She let out a refined chuckle. "We would go and park somewhere, have our high school make-out session, and then we would lay on top of the old sleeping bag in the back of the wagon in our birthday suits and stare at the wagon's ceiling, talking about what we wanted to do in the future... I never in a million years would have thought — let alone talked about, let alone imagined — what we just experienced the past couple weeks." She stopped for a drink from the water bottle.

"You, Miss Nancy, are never a bother. On the contrary — you are always a breath of fresh air in this somewhat old, stale mansion." Smithers crimped another edge. "Do you know what the world's greatest fix for a computer is? Or, for that matter, most electronic equipment?"

"Smithers, I don't."

"It is the old unplug-and-then-plug-back-in method. You see, when a system gets lost in itself, or confused, and can't figure out

the correct route, sometimes the quickest and easiest fix is to pull the plug. Let it recover and start fresh. Perhaps your search for memories is simply your system wanting to reset itself to a simpler time?"

Nancy crossed the kitchen, stood behind him, and gave him a hug — which Smithers received with the dignity of a man being knighted.

"Derek always says your wisdom greatly exceeds your age. Maybe, Smithers, you are actually older than this place." She laughed.

The toaster popped in perfect rhythm with her laugh.

She released him. "Have you seen Larry this morning? I need his expertise on a... technical matter."

"Mister Leland arrived at his usual time. I believe he's conducting diagnostics in the lower levels. Shall I have him meet you in the study?"

"No, I'll find him. Best if we..." A hesitation, small but visible to a professional observer, of which the kitchen contained at least one. "...discuss this in person."

"Very good, Miss Nancy. Though might I suggest the east basement corridor? The acoustics are particularly... discreet."

Nancy paused at the door and studied Smithers's perfectly composed expression, which returned the study without a flicker.

"Smithers, how much do you actually know about what goes on in this house?"

Smithers began arranging fresh scones on a silver tray. "I merely observe, Miss Nancy. Though the mansion..." — a slight smile — "...does enjoy sharing its observations."

"And that is why everyone loves you, Smithers." She smiled and left the kitchen.

In the corridor beyond, two mirrors faced each other across the hall, and in them, a pair of the mansion's newborn smart alecks convened.

"I tell ya, when I used to exercise, I got no respect!" Rodney Dangerfield's reflection adjusted his tie in the first mirror. "My trainer told me to run like someone was chasing me... turns out it was just my reflection!" A tug at the collar. "But Mrs. K here, she's got the right idea — when you look that good running, even the ghosts stop to stare!"

"Oh my god, oh my god..." Chris Farley's reflection materialized in the opposite mirror, wringing his hands. "Rodney, show some respect! Though..." — and here he shifted into full motivational-speaker voice — "...speaking as someone who LIVED IN A VAN DOWN BY THE RIVER, I can say with absolute certainty that Derek living in THIS MANSION is directly related to THAT SPECTACULAR POSTERIOR!"

"And here I had a whole routine about my wife's exercise bike — she uses it every day... to hang her laundry!" Rodney tugged the tie again. "But Farley's right. With a posterior like that, even my doctor would prescribe jogging!"

Thunder rumbled softly — almost like a warning.

Both reflections vanished a half-second before Nancy passed, wearing the innocence of mirrors everywhere.



## CHAPTER THREE

### OFF THE BOOKS

Nancy descended the basement stairs, following the soft hum of Larry's equipment. The mansion's circuits pulsed brighter along the walls as she approached — the house's equivalent of a dog hearing the leash come off its hook. Through a partially open door, she found Larry examining readings across multiple screens, air-drumming absently with a voltage meter.

She knocked softly. "Larry? Got a minute?"

The headphones came off at speed; the professional demeanor snapped into place over the drummer like a dust cover.

"Morning, Miss Nancy. Just checking a bunch of readings after yesterday's odd power fluctuations. They seem to be happening more frequently. I should mention this to Master Kinison so he can check the status of the current protection protocol."

Nancy closed the door behind her.

"Actually, I need your help with something... off the books. Something Derek doesn't need to know about yet. Are you okay with that? If not, I will fully understand, Larry."

Larry set down his tools, and the last of the drummer left his expression. "Does this have anything to do with the energy spikes I've been detecting from the church?"

"I don't know, Larry, but I need to set up surveillance. Small cameras, completely undetectable. Covering all the church entrances — especially the ones Linda... Rebecca... whatever she calls herself, doesn't want us to know about. Is it possible to have the cameras record everyone that comes and goes and transfer those

images to my tablet daily?"

Larry moved to a storage cabinet and retrieved a metal case. Inside, nested in foam: dozens of tiny devices, each smaller than a thumbnail.

"These connect to the mansion's energy network — like wireless cameras, but using Mr. Rhodes' special technology that will visually hide the camera. Kinda like the camouflage they used in Arnold's movie 'Predator.' I believe the energy field currently extends beyond the town, so it should easily do what you need."

Nancy lifted one of the devices, turning it in the light. "These won't be detected by whatever Acid Burn left behind?"

"That's the interesting part, Miss Nancy. These don't just observe — they're like tiny extensions of the mansion's consciousness. They not only record everything, but the mansion's system will actually analyze the feed and determine if it should notify us of what is happening. It's like having a full-time person watching the feed 24/7. They're able to use the quantum field like a Wi-Fi connection would act. They see what we see."

Through the basement window, storm clouds gathered against a morning that had been advertised as clear. Thunder rumbled softly — almost approvingly.

"How soon can we—"

The lights flickered. Every screen in the room filled with the same message:

ENERGY SIGNATURE DETECTED — LOCATION:  
CHURCH BASEMENT

Larry's eyes went to the readings, and his voice dropped into its serious register, the one with no drum solos in it anywhere.

"Miss Nancy... I think someone just activated that cube thing again. Look at the signal graph on the left and compare it to the



signal graph on the right. The one on the right was what we recorded during the breach."

The two waveforms sat side by side on the screen, and even to a gallery owner with no engineering degree, they were siblings.

The mansion's lights dimmed, just perceptibly — the whole house leaning in to look.

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## CHAPTER FOUR

### PROTOTYPE 2

Larry moved between monitors with the focused intensity of a man whose morning soundtrack had been replaced by something in a minor key. Nancy studied the energy signature readings over his shoulder.

"Is there any way to tell what they're doing with it?"

"Not exactly, Miss Nancy, but look at these energy patterns." His fingers ran across multiple keyboards. "They're similar to what we saw during the containment breach, but... different somehow. Watch for the sudden spike every half screen."

Along the walls, the mansion's energy patterns pulsed erratically — an irregular heartbeat in a house that had, until recently, kept excellent time.

"Different how?"

"It's like..." He adjusted settings. "...like they're trying to tune it to a specific frequency. Almost like—"

The pipe organ played a single, discordant note that made them both wince.

"The mansion didn't like that at all." Larry checked the new readings. "Whatever they're doing is causing some kind of strange resonance interference."

"Derek is the techie in the family, Larry, but from a common-sense perspective — do you recall when Jonathan mentioned the protection was not a wall but a maze? Is it possible that the protocol is simply changing the maze on a regular basis, trying to stay one step ahead of Acid Burn or whatever they are

trying to do?"

"Well, Miss Nancy, if I may say — for someone who is not the techie, you certainly seem to have an exceptional insight into the techie stuff. I bet you would love the series 'The Expanse.' But to try and answer your question, I think that question is better suited for Mr. K and AISAM. I know the protocol is constantly monitoring every system, so I would guess they are aware of these daily attempts to breach our system. And knowing Mr. R, he is a very smart cookie."

Two floors up, in the kitchen, Smithers calmly removed his perfectly cooked apple pie from the oven. Baked into the crust — where a lattice ought to have been — was a pattern that had not been there when the pie went in. A warning symbol, rendered in golden pastry.

"Yes, I see," Smithers said to the pie. "Most concerning indeed."

In the basement, Nancy's tablet chimed: incoming video call, Derek.

"Not now..." She declined it.

"Miss Nancy, look at this—"

Every monitor switched to the same image: a complex electronic schematic, labeled in confident mid-century drafting hand.

PROTOTYPE 2 — CONSCIOUSNESS AMPLIFIER — J.  
RHODES 1957

"Larry... is that what I think it is?"

Larry studied the diagram. "If you're thinking it looks exactly like that cube Acid Burn was using at Mr. Weber's office... then yes, Miss Nancy. Except this one..." — he zoomed in on the details — "...this one was designed to work with the mansion's systems. Not try to attack it."

Thunder rumbled closer. Through the basement window, the storm clouds had arranged themselves into familiar geometric patterns — directly above the church.

"How long would it take to set up those surveillance cameras at the church?"

Larry was already retrieving equipment from cabinets with practiced efficiency. "With the energy field boost I can initiate, maybe an hour. But Miss Nancy..." He hesitated. "...if they detect any unusual activity around the church—"

"Then we'll have to be extra careful, Larry. I need to know what's happening in that basement. Something tells me we're running out of time."

The lights flickered again. One monitor switched to the front gate security feed: a black Mercedes, gliding up the drive like a shark that had learned to valet.

"What does she want today?"

"Back entrance through the garden in twenty minutes?" Larry was packing surveillance gear at speed. "I know a route where the construction crews won't see us."

Another call from Derek lit up her tablet. Nancy silenced it. "Perfect. I'll change and meet you there."

She moved to leave, then paused at the door.

"Larry? Thank you. I know Derek and I probably don't say this enough to you, but we are both so appreciative of everything you have done for us and the mansion. If you didn't know it, Larry — you're family now. And I know this little covert exercise puts you in an awkward position."

Larry looked up, surprisingly serious. "Miss Nancy, I could not be happier working for you and Mr. K. I so missed this place, and was thinking of moving away a few months ago. But now — I

wouldn't change jobs for all the macaroni and cheese in the world. After what we saw during the containment breach... I don't think any of us can afford to stay neutral anymore."

The mansion's circuits pulsed in agreement. In a nearby mirror, Jonathan Rhodes' reflection nodded, once, approvingly.

Outside, the Mercedes had stopped in front of the mansion, and Linda — Rebecca — had begun inspecting the renovations one by one, walking the grounds with a clipboard air that required no actual clipboard.

Nancy hurried through the great room and nearly collided with Smithers, who had materialized in her path bearing, draped over one arm, an item of knitwear.

"Might I suggest the green cardigan for your excursion, Miss Nancy? The weather appears to be turning... unpredictable."

Nancy paused, studying his perfectly composed expression.

"The mansion really does tell you everything, doesn't it?"

"Let's just say..." Smithers adjusted his bow tie, then helped her into the cardigan with valet precision. "...it appreciates having someone to talk to during the long night shift. But it was actually Master Farley that suggested the cardigan."

"Smithers, is there a Mrs. Smithers?"

"That, Miss Nancy, is a conversation for another time. Mr. Leland, I believe, is expecting you. And don't worry — I will handle Mrs. Rhodes, unless Master Kinison arrives home before I can get rid of her. I am sure she is being her usual busybody self, as usual."

Nancy placed her hand over his where it rested on her shoulder. "I look forward to that, Smithers."

From somewhere deep in the mansion, the pipe organ played a few bars of "Secret Agent Man."



## CHAPTER FIVE

### THE MS. PEEL MANEUVER

The church sat in its Sunday-best stillness, and two figures who were absolutely not trained operatives moved along its flank with the tactical vocabulary of people who had watched a great many movies.

They placed the first camera in a nearby tree. Then, in a low, coordinated scuttle that would have made an actual field officer weep into their coffee, they advanced on the side door.

The final device went in behind a decorative cornerstone, positioned with jeweler's care by Larry's steady hands. It pulsed once — then seemed to fade into the stone itself, the camouflage swallowing it whole.

Larry concealed the last of the equipment while Nancy kept watch, the storm clouds overhead continuing their strange geometric dance, patient as a chess clock.

"This is the last one," Larry whispered. "The energy field is strong here, but..." He checked his readings. "...there's something else. Some kind of interference."

The basement windows lit with a familiar blue glow. A high-pitched whine began building at the very edge of hearing, the sound of something enormous inhaling.

"And you are sure the other four cameras are not going to be detected?" Nancy's eyes swept the grounds — and caught movement. "Larry. Visitors..."

"I see it. We need to—"

The church bells began to toll.

It was not the hour. And the sound was wrong in a way that bypassed the ears entirely and went straight to the teeth — harmonics that human bell-founders had spent centuries learning to avoid.

Up the church's stone flank, geometric patterns began to spread — through the masonry itself, the same patterns as the mansion's walls, surfacing like veins beneath cold skin.

"I think we just ran out of time," Nancy said.

They scrambled to gather the equipment as the tolling continued, the patterns in the stone reaching toward them like hungry fingers.

"It's like the stone doesn't want to let go..." Larry strained at a sensor that had bonded to the wall.

"What do you mean the stone doesn't—"

The sensor came free all at once, and they stumbled backward together — and stopped.

Where the sensor had been, decades of weathering had flaked away. Beneath: carved symbols. They matched the mansion's patterns exactly.

"Larry... how long has the church been here?"

Larry checked his tablet. "According to town records, 1893. But these markings..." He studied the carvings. "...they're using the same energy patterns as the mansion. Miss Nancy, I don't think Jonathan Rhodes designed these patterns. I think he may have found them."

A shadow fell across them.

They looked up from the stairwell to find Rebecca standing at the top of the church's side entrance, her perfectly composed smile stopping several inches short of her eyes.



"I was just out at the mansion, Ms. Hammond, looking for you and Mr. Kinison, to see how your renovations are progressing." A pause, precisely weighted. "Doing some historical research, Mrs. Hammond?"

Nancy stepped smoothly in front of Larry's equipment bag. "Just admiring the architecture. The geometric patterns are fascinating."

"Oh, you have no idea." Rebecca descended a few steps with unnatural grace, the way water moves when it has decided to be a person. "Though I'm surprised Derek let you come alone, given recent... events."

"Actually, Miss Rhodes," Larry said, calmly packing the last sensor, "I was just showing Miss Nancy some of the restoration work we did on the mansion's stone. Thought she might be interested in similar period craftsmanship for the mansion renovations."

"How thoughtful, Mr. Leland. Though you really should see the basement, since you are here. The patterns down there are... quite extraordinary."

Thunder crashed directly overhead. The blue glow from the basement windows pulsed like a heartbeat.

And Nancy saw, now, what the shadow at the top of the stairs had been concealing: Rebecca had not come alone. Perhaps six council members stood arranged behind her, spaced with the pleasing regularity of fence posts.

"Maybe another time. We should get back—"

"Oh, but I insist. The council would love your... artistic perspective on our renovation plans." Rebecca turned to her colleagues.

"Yes, absolutely." "It's really amazing." "Very rare." "I am sure it will inspire you." "Your art gallery experience would be very

beneficial." The endorsements arrived in no particular order and yet somehow in perfect coordination, like a choir sight-reading enthusiasm.

The church doors swung open behind her. In the shadows beyond, more council members. Their movements were oddly synchronized, a room full of people sharing three gestures between them.

"That's very kind," Nancy said, and the nervousness had reached her voice now, one degree of it, "but Larry and I have a meeting with the mansion's contractors—"

"Ah, there you are, Miss Nancy."

The voice arrived from the path behind them, and with it — materializing out of the afternoon like a corrective footnote from a better century — came Smithers, in a full-length coat and top hat, walking cane in hand, dressed to stroll 1850s London.

"Master Kinison has returned early and is quite eager to discuss the new security protocols with you and Mr. Leland."

Rebecca's expression flickered — one frame of annoyance in an otherwise seamless broadcast.

"Smithers. Always so... unwantingly punctual."

"Indeed, Mrs. Blackwood. Councilors." Smithers inclined his head at the assembly. "Though I believe your grandfather was even more particular about timing. Especially regarding certain... experiments."

The name landed. Rebecca's perfect composure cracked, hairline-thin — and the council members behind her recoiled from Smithers's proximity, all of them, in the same instant, like iron filings from the wrong pole.

"You know nothing about my grandfather's work." The attitude in it was unconcealed now; whatever Rebecca was, she did not like

Smithers.

"On the contrary. I served at Ravencrest during his entire tenure. Including that rather unfortunate incident with the original quantum amplifier. As I recall, the explosion left quite distinctive geometric scarring in the stone."

The church bells stopped, mid-toll.

The blue glow faded.

The whole place went silent — the abrupt, held-breath silence of a room where someone has said the unsayable and everyone is waiting to see what breaks.

"Another time, then, Ms. Hammond." Rebecca recovered her smile, though it came back colder, a few degrees closer to its natural temperature. "Though you really shouldn't keep people waiting, Nancy... Deadlines have a way of... accelerating."

She turned and ascended the steps with artificial precision. The council members melted back into the shadows. The doors seemed to close on their own.

Across the street, in the dusty window of a shop that had been closed for years, the scene sat reflected in old glass — the church, the retreating figures, the three of them on the path — and if anyone had been watching the reflection rather than the street, they might have noticed it held the image a half-second longer than the street did, the way a thing lingers when someone, somewhere, is studying it.



## CHAPTER SIX

### THE LONG WALK HOME

They followed Smithers along a path toward the side street where Nancy had parked out of sight.

"Smithers, is Derek really—"

"Master Kinison is still in San Francisco, Miss Nancy." Smithers was already leading them onward. "Though I suspect we should return to the mansion. Quickly."

"I think Linda — or I guess I should call her Rebecca — is not too happy with my meddling around here. And for that matter, the town."

"Might I suggest that future trips to town would be better if myself or Mr. Leland accompany you. At least for the short term. Or Master Kinison, for those trips where we don't refer to you as 007." A beat, immaculate. "Or would you prefer Ms. Peel?"

Nancy returned a quick smile. "Where is your car, Smithers?"

"I walked, Miss Nancy. I don't drive."

Larry checked his readings as they went. "The signal interference... it's changing. Like it's trying to lock onto something."

"Any chance they're detecting the other cameras?"

"No... and they are already providing a feed back to the mansion."

"Great. I am confident that we are going to figure out Linda/Rebecca's game."

"A game, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "implies that there will be a winner and a loser."

"Well, we all know what team we are on!"

They piled into Nancy's little Mini Cooper — recently liberated from storage and relocated to the mansion, a car that fit Smithers's top hat the way a thimble fits a heron — and pulled away.

Behind them, through the church's stained glass, Rebecca stood watching their retreat. And in the colored panes, her reflection showed something beneath the perfect facade — something with proportions the facade was working hard to contain.

"Smithers, how did you know—"

"The mansion has rather strong opinions about Mrs. Blackwood's renovation interests, Miss Nancy. It was quite insistent I go for a walk today."

"You are always welcome to use my bike anytime, you know," Larry offered.

"Thank you, Larry, but sometimes a good walk is what the doctor orders."

"Mr. Smithers." Larry's voice shifted — the serious register again. "How much do you actually know about the original experiments?"

Smithers straightened his cuffs thoughtfully as the mansion rose ahead of them.

"Let's just say some of us have been protecting Ravencrest's secrets longer than others. Though I suspect we're all about to learn precisely why those protections were necessary."

Behind them, over the town, the pipe organ's notes carried faintly across the grounds — a warning traveling as music. And overhead, in an otherwise cloud-free sky, the storm clouds had drawn themselves into a perfect pattern connecting church and mansion: a giant circuit board, sketched across the heavens by something that wanted the two buildings to remember they were wired together.

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## CHAPTER SEVEN

### THE STONES REMEMBER

Late afternoon light slanted into the great room, where Nancy — still wearing her makeshift attempt at blending-in-locally attire — paced a groove into the rug while Larry analyzed data from the surveillance cameras. Smithers arranged a fresh tea service and a few rice crispy squares with practiced calm, undisturbed by the mansion's increasingly erratic behavior around him: lights pulsing, patterns shifting along the walls, the pipe organ emitting the occasional discordant note like a patient muttering in its sleep.

"Why now?" Nancy said. "What changed?"

"The energy disturbance..." Larry studied his screens. "It's exactly like what we saw during the containment breach, but... different somehow. Like they're trying to pull something in instead of keeping something out."

"Perhaps it's less about what changed, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, pouring tea with a steady hand, "and more about what was... remembered."

"What do you mean?"

"Dr. Blackwood's early experiments didn't begin with consciousness transfer. They started with something far more ambitious — accessing memories stored in stone itself."

Thunder crashed. The mansion's patterns pulsed urgently, punctuation from the walls.

"Stored in stone? I think your geophysics is above my pay grade, Smithers."

"Perhaps you can think of stone not as stone, but simply atoms and protons arranged in such a way as to look and feel like stone — but under certain conditions, could be rearranged to form something entirely different."

"Now you're sounding like Derek watching a Star Trek episode. Perhaps, Smithers, you just may have missed your calling as a professor at a university."

"Miss Nancy, look at this—"

Larry's screens displayed architectural drawings of both buildings — church and mansion, overlaid. The geometric patterns aligned perfectly. Two sets of lines, drawn generations apart, interlocking into a single larger circuit like two hands folding together.

"The church and mansion..." Nancy studied the diagram. "They're connected?"

"More than connected, Miss Nancy. They're two halves of the same machine. Though I doubt even Dr. Blackwood understood its true purpose."

The pipe organ played a warning chord — and on the security feed, Derek's Tesla appeared, pulling into the drive.

"Larry, shut it down. All of it. We'll figure this out later."

"Already on it." Larry's hands moved across the keyboards. "But Miss Nancy..." He hesitated. "...the energy field is still active around the church. And it looks like it is growing stronger."

"I believe, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "the time has come to share certain... historical context with Master Kinison."

Through the windows, the storm clouds continued their impossible geometric dance as the Tesla parked.



"Not yet. Let me talk to him first. He already read me the riot act about spying on Linda/Rebecca. I am sure he would not be as diplomatic as you, calling me Ms. Peel. But... if Rebecca knows we were there—"

"Miss Nancy... there's something else." Larry's voice had dropped. "Whatever that cube they're using... it's not just tapping into the mansion's power. It's... I think, learning from it now."

The great room's double doors opened. Derek entered carrying his small overnight bag — and stopped two steps in, reading the room with the instincts of a man who had spent fifteen years walking into meetings that had started without him.

"Gee. Here I thought I would be greeted at the front door with a hug and a bouquet of roses."

"I am sorry, hun — we have been chatting here for a bit and I must have been distracted. Bad AISAM! Bad AISAM, for not letting me know Derek was back." The attempt at lightness was valiant and fooled no one, least of all its author.

"Nancy? Why do I feel like I missed something important?"

Before she could answer, every mirror in the mansion activated simultaneously — all of them showing the same image: Jonathan Rhodes, decades younger, demonstrating a device that looked very much like the cube from the church basement. The original quantum amplifier. The date stamp in the corner read April 8th, 1992.

"Is that—"

"The night before your uncle's final performance, Master Kinison," Smithers said. "And Dr. Blackwood's last experiment."

The pipe organ began playing "The Times They Are A-Changin'," the mansion's patterns pulsing in perfect rhythm.

"So." Derek set down the bag. "What did I miss?"

"How is Charles?" Nancy tried, shifting lanes with the smoothness of a driver who knows she's been clocked. "And how did the Jacobson meeting go?"

"Smithers, any chance I could have one of your special hot chocolates? And a rice crispy square, if you have any left."

"Absolutely, Master Kinison. I am on it." Smithers withdrew toward the kitchen.

"Well, Charles was..." Derek searched for it. "...how do I put it... not the Charles I remember two weeks ago. He looks the same, but there is just something about him that is off. It's almost like the current Charles is pretending to be the old Charles and just can't do it exactly. Does that make sense to you — or are you trying to avoid answering my question?"

"Do you think something infected him? Or is responsible for his behavior after what happened to him here?"

"That is exactly what I am thinking. I was trying to retrace my interactions with Charles when he was here. I did leave him alone a few times, and maybe he went poking around and found Jonathan's old helmet and stuck it on."

"I guess it now begs the question — who, or what, infected him?"

"Or what indeed." Derek studied his wife. "So. What have you been up to?"

Nancy started to pace the room, and Derek recognized the pattern immediately — the old *how do I bring this up to Derek* circuit, unchanged since high school. And a second observation filed itself alongside the first: she was dressed head to toe in green, in clothes she would never choose, looking like an ad for a hiking catalog she'd never read.

"Derek... there's something you need to know about the church. About all of it."

Through the great room's windows, the cloud patterns tightened across the sky like a net drawing closed around both buildings.

"Mr. K..." Larry checked his readings one last time. "I think whatever they're planning — it may have already started."

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Across town, beneath the church, Rebecca stood before an altar-like array of equipment.

The cube pulsed with dark energy above it while council members arranged themselves around her in a geometric pattern — each one finding a position, a vertex, a purpose, until the room itself became a diagram.

"Time to wake up, grandfather." Rebecca raised her arms toward the ceiling. "The stones remember... and so will everyone else."

As if on cue, the council members began to produce a sound.

It was a collective vocalization best described as an Austrian alphorn rendered in human throats — a deep, sustained, resonant drone. And it moved: pitch and tone shifting in coordination, voices braiding and unbraiding, a well-rehearsed choir performing a hymn written before hymns.

The chant swelled. And across both buildings — church and mansion, two halves of one machine — the energy patterns flashed with impossible light.

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## CHAPTER EIGHT

### PARTNERS

The mansion's systems pulsed with slowly mounting urgency, a timer with opinions, while Derek processed what Nancy and Larry had just finished telling him. Outside the great room windows, the cloud patterns continued their ominous formation dance.

"So while I was in San Francisco, you two decided to investigate the church... alone? Even after our little talk, and you promising me that you would not play detective with Linda."

"Well, I was not alone — Larry was with me. At my asking, by the way. We had to know what Rebecca was planning. After what happened during the containment breach—"

"Nice try, Nancy. You knew what I meant. You could have been—" He stopped himself. Took a breath. Redirected at the nearest available bystander. "Larry, I thought you would know better than to do something like that."

He paced, and the silence filled the room to the ceiling.

"Larry, what exactly did your readings show?"

"Derek." Nancy stepped into his path. "You can be mad at me. But I was the one that asked Larry — and in fact, had to kinda force him to do it. It's not Larry's fault, or Smithers's. It's all me. So if you want to be mad, or take a strip out of anyone, do it to me!"

"So what was this? A little Charlie's Angels type outing? Or maybe you prefer that I call it 'Three's Company'?" He was noticeably upset now, the volume climbing.

"Derek, we are partners in this. And while I appreciate your concern for my safety, you need to suck it up and realize that I am a

very capable person, who can think for myself, and make difficult decisions. I built that gallery on my own. I know you are only looking out for me — but please. Look at me as your partner. Not as your helpless wife."

She walked to the sideboard, took a Kleenex, and dabbed her eyes — furious at the tears for showing up to a fight they hadn't been invited to.

"I am sorry, Nancy." The volume had gone out of him all at once. "But it would kill me if anything ever happened to you. All this was my idea, and had I known this would happen, I never would have come here."

"Well, I wish to look at it a bit different. We have not felt this alive in years. Everything about us is so much better. From the hickey monster to dancing in the great room with you. From the way we look at each other now, to the exhilaration that we both felt these last two weeks. I, for one, would not trade this for a double quantum processor experience." And there it was — her cute smile, deployed with full knowledge of its armament classification.

"Mr. Leland." Smithers had appeared at the doorway with the timing of a man who had been listening at exactly the right distance. "I need your assistance in the kitchen for a bit."

Larry — who had spent the entire exchange standing with his back to them, radiating the profound discomfort of a man trapped inside someone else's marriage — grabbed his tablets and hurried out at a pace just short of jogging.

Derek crossed to Nancy, put his arms around her, and looked into her eyes.

"You are the best thing that has ever happened to me. I know you're smart, capable, and oh so beautiful. At times I feel I don't deserve you. You are my world — as corny as that sounds, because it sounds corny to say. I am sorry. I have been a bit overprotective,

and I will do my best to change my ways. But you will have to be a little tolerant if I slip every now and then. I love you so much. You're my IT-GIRL." He pressed a sweet kiss to her forehead. "And for the record — Rodney would never let me do the double quantum processor. Only the triple quantum processor." The smile that accompanied this was enormous.

And the pipe organ, which had been waiting through the entire argument with uncharacteristic restraint, chose its moment: the opening bars of the Righteous Brothers' "Unchained Melody" rolled through the great room.

Nancy began to sway, holding Derek exactly the way she had held him their very first dance together at the old Collins Hotel — and softly, she began to sing.

[AUTHOR INSERT — lyric, per script p.22]

The song filled the room around them, and the walls joined in.

In the largest mirror, Bobby Hatfield's reflection appeared and took the melody over from Nancy, carrying it the way only he ever could. And down the length of the great room, mirror by mirror, the mansion's digital children gathered to watch: smiling, swaying to the music, an audience of legends gone soft at the sight of two people dancing — except for Chris Farley, who was bawling his eyes out and waving a handkerchief at them.

The last mirror held Sam.

Not Sam Kinison the comedian. Uncle Sam the man — beret and all, watching his kid dance with the girl from the blue station wagon, thirty-some years and one impossible resurrection later.

He formed a heart with his hands, and placed it over his own.



## CHAPTER NINE

### FILTERS WHOM?

An hour later, the study had reconvened as a war room, with cheese.

Smithers arranged a tray of cheeses and set out sniffers for the Taylor Fladgate thirty-year-old port while Larry pulled up data across the screens.

"It's like the mansion's energy field is being... inverted somehow. The mansion's protection protocols are still active, but—"

The pipe organ played a deep, resonant note that made the windows vibrate in their frames.

Every mirror in the study lit at once, each showing a different moment from Jonathan's experiments: Rebecca as a young girl, watching her grandfather work. The original quantum amplifier being installed. Sam's final performance setup. The night of the containment breach. A family album of catastrophe, dealt out face-up.

"I believe the mansion is trying to tell us something rather urgent," Smithers said, studying the images while the port breathed, "about history repeating itself."

Thunder crashed. And now the geometric patterns in both buildings began pulsing in alternating rhythm — two hearts beating out of sync, each trying to set the other's tempo.

"Derek, look at the dates on these experiments. They all happened right before—"

"Before Sam died. And Dr. Blackwood disappeared." Derek turned from the mirrors. "Does anyone have any info about old Doc Blackwood's disappearance?"

"Mr. K, these energy readings... they're exactly like the ones from your uncle's last show, I think. But amplified. Whatever that cube is doing—"

Every electronic device in the mansion activated simultaneously. Screens filled with scrolling code, and out of the chaos came AISAM's voice:

"Kid, we've got a problem. They're not just accessing the mansion's security field... they're trying to reverse the entire consciousness transfer network! Return the system back to what it was before the containment breach."

"Reverse it? What happens if they—"

"Everything we contained..." Jonathan appeared in the mirrors, his image taut with urgency. "...everyone we saved... they'll all be contained wrong. They will be infected! The maze doesn't just protect, Derek. It... filters."

"Filters what?" Nancy asked.

"Perhaps, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "the better question is: filters whom?"



At the church, the energy patterns surged with blinding intensity. In the tower, the bells began tolling in a rhythm no human bell-ringer could produce and no human ear could forgive.

"Time to wake up, grandfather," Rebecca's voice echoed through the energy field itself, carried on it, part of it now. "The stones remember..."





## CHAPTER TEN

### LET THE SHOW BEGIN

In the church tower, Rebecca smiled as her grandfather's original device pulsed with dark energy.

She pulled a large lever.

From the top of the tower, with a grinding of stone and machinery that had waited the better part of a century for this cue, a massive antenna rose — wrapped in pulsing blue conduits that branched and twitched like veins, like the tower had grown a nervous system and this was its spine.

On a rooftop two streets over — a hardware store closed for the night, its ladder access supposedly locked — someone stood watching the antenna climb. Gloved hands raised a small instrument toward the tower, held it level, and kept it there through the whole slow ascent, patient as a surveyor. When the antenna reached its full height and the blue light steadied, the instrument came down, and the rooftop went back to being the kind of place nothing ever happens.

Below, in the basement, the ritual had reached capacity.

The room was filled with people in strange robes and stranger headgear — headsets that were, to any eye that had visited Derek's office, unmistakably Oculus Xros, the same units Global Dynamics used for client demos, here repurposed for something considerably older than marketing. The cube hung mounted above the altar, exactly as it had been the night Marina lay there.

Tonight's vessel was already in place.

Tied between two pillars, dressed by someone else's hands and conscious by only the most generous definition, sagged Chad Wellington III — looking, for all the world, like a man who had just finished partying with Sam and lost.

The chant rolled through the chamber, gathering:

"Rise, old lord. We give you this vessel. The Stones Remember. The Stones Contain. The Stones Release..."

In the tower, Rebecca raised her arms to the storm clouds wheeling overhead.

"You want to filter, Jonathan... Filter this."

The sky answered — a massive lightning show erupting above the church, the clouds' geometry cracking open with light.

"Let the show begin."

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## CURTAIN CALL

*As the last light fades over Ravenscrest, the pipe organ plays an unsettling rendition of "In Dreams" through the darkened halls, and beneath it, if you listen, the whispers come — overlapping, rising, patient:*

*"The stones remember... the stones remember... the stones—"*

*And cutting through them, one voice that never needed a microphone:*

*"Careful what you wish for, sweetheart. Some memories bite back."*

*Thunder crashes, one final time.*

*And then — because this house has never once ended an evening on a down note — the organ softens, and the melody transforms into the Roy Orbison version, and through the mansion's halls a single large mirror seems to drift from room to room, collecting the family one reflection at a time. Each of them gets their moment — a signature move, a bow, a turn:*

*Derek. Nancy. Smithers. Larry. Earl. Linda-who-is-Rebecca. Chad. Pete. Sam. Jonathan. Rodney. George Carlin. John Candy. Norm Macdonald. Gilbert Gottfried. Meat Loaf.*

*One by one, dancing their dance, until the mirror finally goes dark.*



*So the gallery girl's a spy now, the handyman's a one-man variety show, and the real estate lady just grew an antenna. And somewhere in a church basement, a kid named Chad is about to find out what happens when you're the vessel and the audience at the same time. Here's the thing about stones, kid — I spent thirty years playing rooms made of them. They*

*remember everything. Every laugh, every bomb, every night you left it all on the stage. The trick isn't making the stones remember you. The trick is making sure they remember you fondly. OH OH OHHHH — intermission.*

*Don't go anywhere.*

## END OF BOOK EIGHT

## ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

*Living With the Ghost of Sam* is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

## ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

*The Last Axiom* (Books 1–15)

*A Letter Guide for Rebecca*